

CROSS-ASSET TRADING PLAYBOOK

Prop Desk Edition

VWAP • options flow • volume profile • DOM / order book • session strategy

Real-market trade reconstructions for training and process design

US equities

Crypto ETFs

FX

Commodities

DESIGNED FOR

Discretionary traders,
coaches, desk leads

CORE TOOLS

VWAP stack, options flow,
volume profile, DOM

BUILD

Prop Desk Edition
March 2026

This manual is designed to move a trader from chart recognition into repeatable cross-asset execution. The same five questions appear on every desk-quality trade: What is the regime? Where is location? Is flow confirming? Which session should actually pay? What invalidates the idea before P&L starts negotiating with you?

The playbook covers US equities, FX, crypto ETF expression, and commodity ETFs through the same lens. Each real-market case study is a rules-based reconstruction from public daily OHLCV data; the charts are for training and process design, not a claim of audited fills.

What makes this prop-level: every page forces a decision - press, reduce, or pass. If location is weak, size down. If flow disagrees, wait. If risk is undefined, there is no trade.

How to use this manual

Read it in order the first time. After that, use it as a desk reference: framework first, liquidity map second, flow tools third, then the case studies when you need a model for execution.

SCOUT Map catalyst, location, and the active session before price leaves value.	COMMIT Size only when price proves away from VWAP/level and flow confirms.	REVIEW Grade the decision quality, not just the outcome. Process compounds faster than prediction.
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What professionals focus on

Desk-quality focus	Typical retail over-focus
Process quality and inventory context	Perfect entries and indicator stacking
Liquidity windows and session behavior	Treating every hour as equally tradable
Location first: AVWAP, value, prior highs/lows	Signal-first trading with no map
Risk budget and correlation heat	Profit fantasy before invalidation

Compliance note: adapt this document with firm-specific disclosures before external distribution. The operating rules and case studies are educational; they are not investment advice or a solicitation.

What changes when you change assets

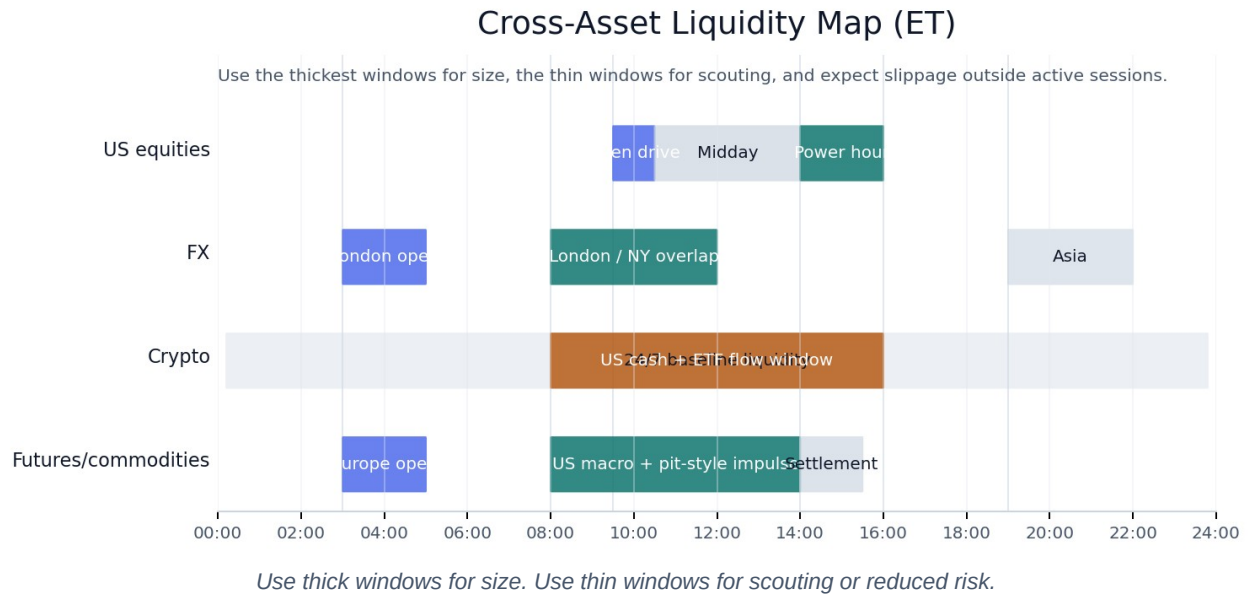
The framework stays the same across assets, but the drivers, thick liquidity windows, and confirmation tools change. A seasoned trader notices that the same idea has to be expressed through the right market structure.

Lens	US equities	FX	Crypto / ETFs	Gold / commodities
Primary driver	Earnings, index flow, options hedging	Rates spread, macro data	ETF flow, perp funding, liquidity regime	Dollar, real rates, supply shocks
Thick window	09:30-10:30 and 15:00-16:00 ET	London open and London/NY overlap	Cash ETF open + 24/7 underlying	Europe open, US macro, settlement
Location map	AVWAP, prior day high/low, HVN/LVN	Prior session range, macro levels	AVWAP, overnight range, funding map	Weekly shelf, AVWAP, prior high
Flow read	Opening auction, DOM, options walls	Rates + dollar, fixing pressure	Perp OI, liquidations, ETF response	Curve behavior, macro cross-check
Aggressive only when	Open drive accepts away from VWAP	Data surprise aligns with rates and dollar	Breakout survives cash flow window or flush reclaim	Breakout holds with macro support
Common trap	Chasing late after a one-way open	Trading dead hours or ignoring carry	Treating thin weekend liquidity as real	Mistaking short covering for durable trend

Same macro shock, different expression: FX often reacts first, indices during cash hours, ETF wrappers at the open, and crypto can move before the desk even turns on.

Liquidity map by asset

The thick windows are where participation is deepest and slippage is cheapest. Outside active sessions, scout or reduce. A trade that only works in thin liquidity is a suspect trade until real participation shows up.

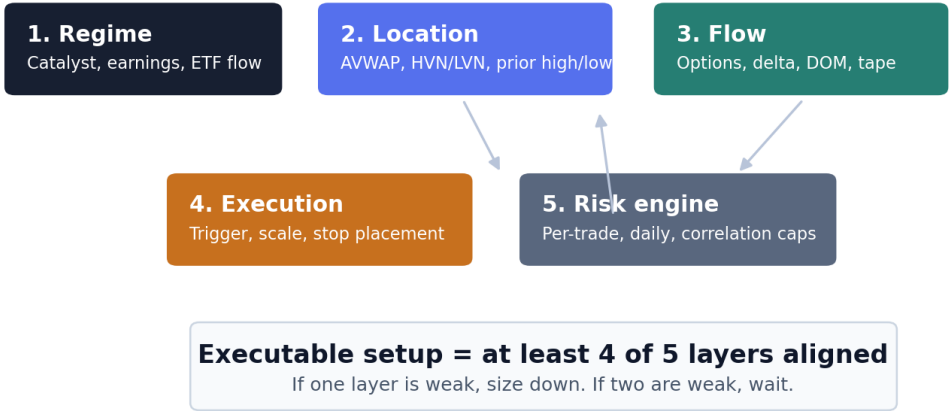


- US equities pay best when the open or close owns the tape; midday requires selective participation.
- FX should be expressed when London and New York overlap unless a major data surprise forces earlier action.
- Crypto ETFs inherit the cash-session behavior of the wrapper even though the underlying trades 24/7.

How a setup graduates from idea to size

The Prop Stack: from idea to executable risk

A setup only gets size when location, flow, and risk align.



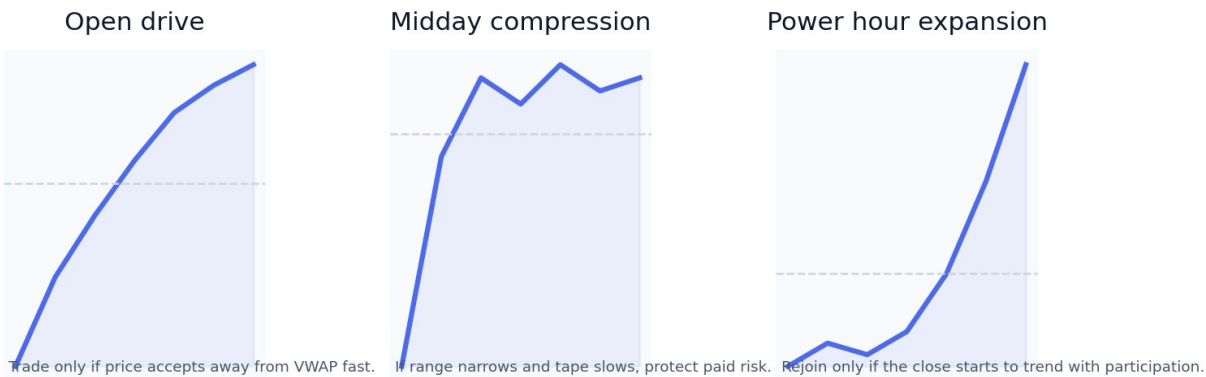
Risk engine rules

Rule	Desk standard
Unit risk	0.25R for a scout, 0.50R for a standard setup, 1.00R only for an A+ alignment.
Daily stop	Stop initiating new risk after -2R realized or after three consecutive process errors.
Add rule	Add only after price proves away from VWAP or the level. Never add on hope into first resistance.
Correlation cap	If multiple positions express the same macro theme, total heat should not exceed 1.5x a single full-size risk.
Stand-down rule	When location and flow disagree, pass. When the session is thin, reduce. When invalidation is vague, do not trade.

Open-to-close routine

Phase	ET	Questions	Primary tools / action
Pre-market	06:30-08:30	What moved overnight? Where is fair value? What is the no-trade zone?	News, overnight range, AVWAP map, profile. Build scenarios before the cash open.
At the open	09:30-10:30	Who owns the open? Is price accepting away from VWAP or failing the first drive?	Session VWAP, breadth, DOM, options walls. Trade initiative only if acceptance shows.
Midday	10:30-13:30	Is the trend still healthy or is the market balancing?	Profile rotation, pullback structure, realized volatility. Reduce size unless structure stays clean.
Into the close	13:30-16:00	Is forced positioning building? Does the close confirm or undo the day?	Dealer levels, ETF flows, closing strength. Press only when the close supports continuation.

Session Playbooks

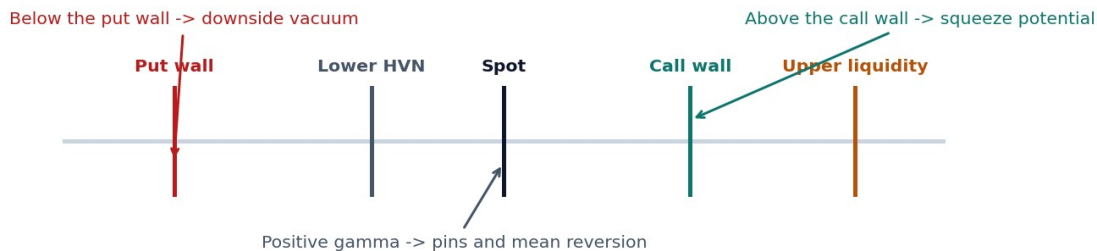


Three repeatable session behaviors: open drive, midday compression, and power-hour expansion.

Options flow and DOM translate location into timing

Options Flow Translation

Use options levels as pressure zones, not as automatic trade signals.



Read the tape

A burst of calls without price acceptance is noise. OI + same-day flow to locate likely pin of takeoff. Takeoff only when price and flow point the same way.

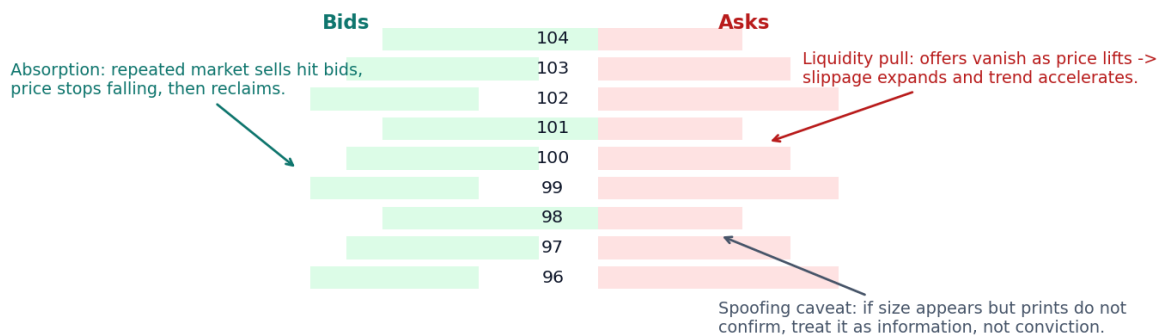
Map dealer pressure

Wait for confirmation

Options levels are pressure zones, not automatic trade signals.

DOM / Order Book Playbook

Read the ladder for intent, then verify on executions. Resting size alone is not enough.



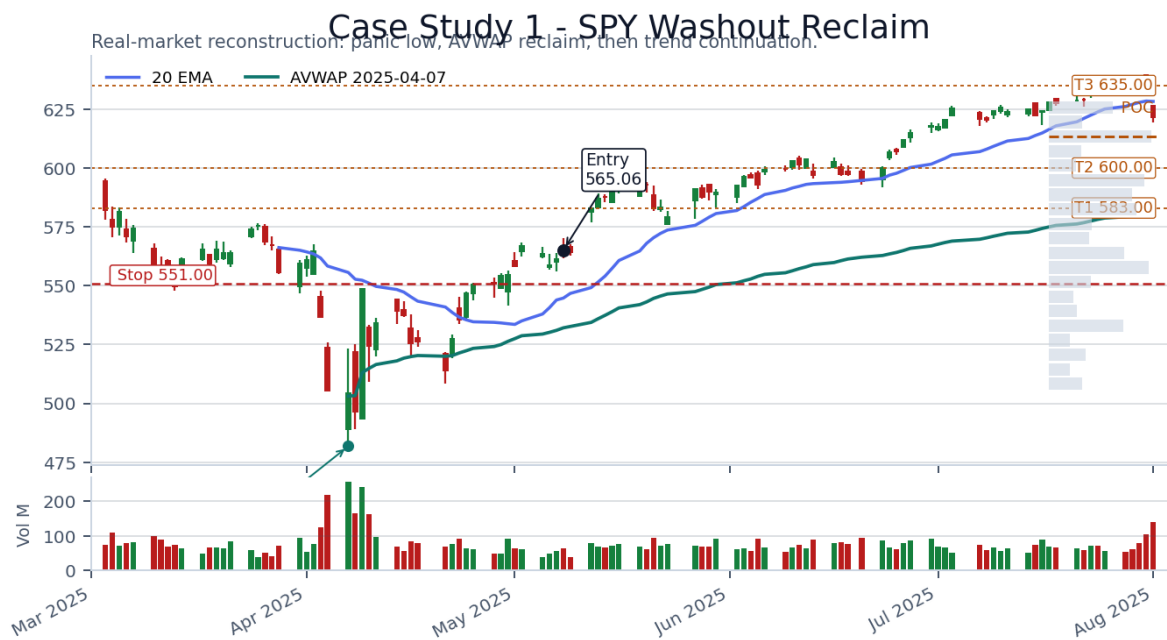
Best practice: DOM + tape + location. If one is missing, you are trading a partial signal.

Resting size is information, not conviction. Read the ladder with prints, not in isolation.

REAL-MARKET CASE STUDY 1 | SPY WASHOUT RECLAIM

Daily candles. Entry uses the close of the signal day; targets are training objectives.

THESIS Panic low fails to continue lower. Reclaiming the washout AVWAP flips trapped shorts into fuel for trend continuation.	TRIGGER Daily close back above AVWAP and the 20 EMA after the April flush; follow-through appears on expanding breadth.	FAILURE Any close that loses the reclaim zone and slips back below AVWAP turns the move into a failed reflex bounce.
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Window volume profile is approximated on the right edge for non-FX charts; FX uses ATR in the lower pane.

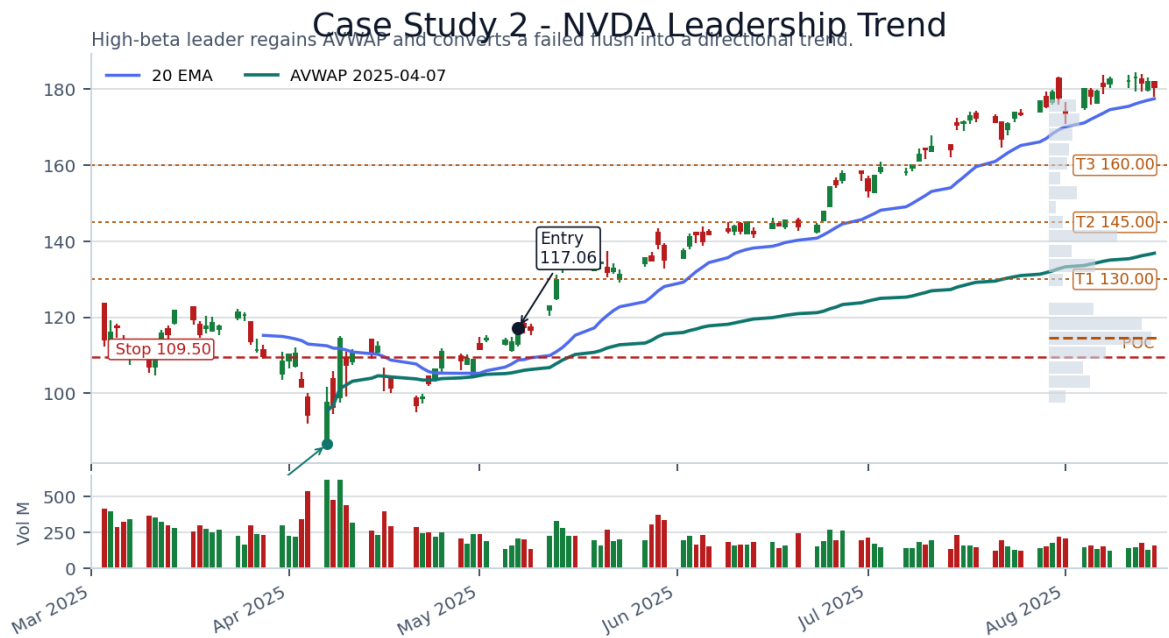
Entry	Stop	Targets	R map	Management
565.06	551.00	583.00 / 600.00 / 635.00	1.28R / 2.49R / 4.97R	Scale one-third into T1, trail the stop under the rising 20 EMA after T2, and only hold runner risk if the close stays constructive. Max swing in window: ~5.32R.

Beginner	Intermediate	Expert
Buy only after the daily close confirms above AVWAP. Use a fixed stop below the reclaimed low and do not add into the first resistance test.	Split the position: partial on the close, partial on the first pullback that respects the reclaim. Reduce on exhaustion into T2 if breadth stalls.	Press size on intraday acceptance above prior-day high when opening auction, index breadth, and index options flow all confirm the reclaim.

REAL-MARKET CASE STUDY 2 | NVDA LEADERSHIP TREND

Daily reconstruction of a leadership trend. Entry is the close of the signal day.

THESIS High-beta leadership reasserts itself as price accepts above the April anchor. Leaders often move first and force the rest of the tape to catch up.	TRIGGER Close above the pivot with the 20 EMA turning higher and AVWAP rising underneath price.	FAILURE Lose the 20 EMA / AVWAP stack and the trend transitions from leadership to distribution.
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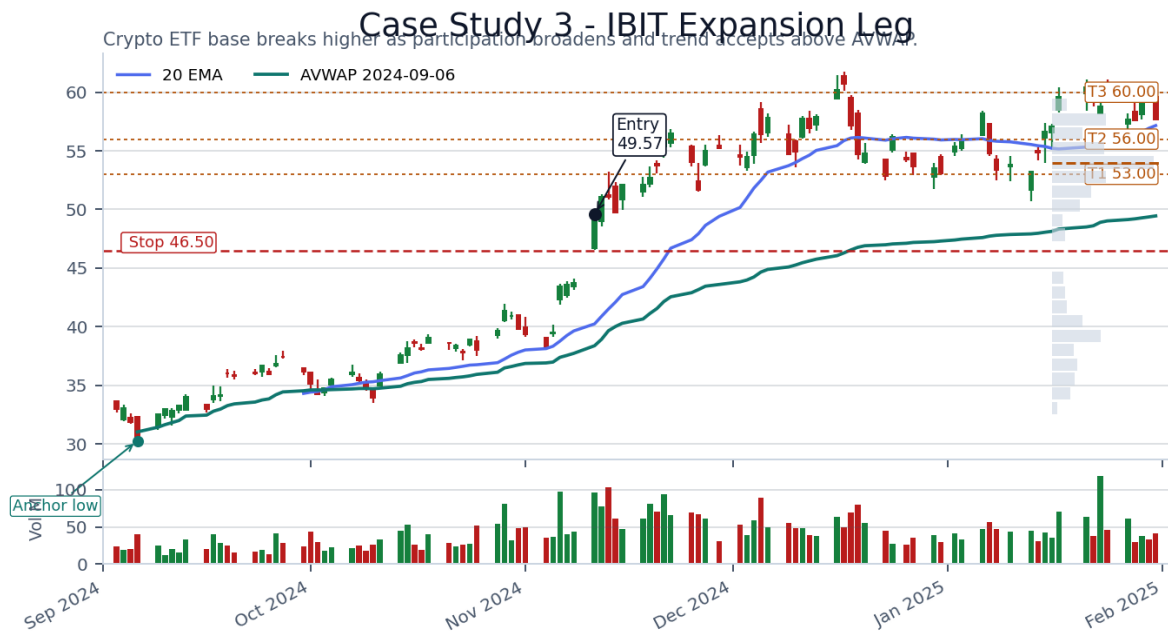
Entry	Stop	Targets	R map	Management
117.06	109.50	130.00 / 145.00 / 160.00	1.71R / 3.70R / 5.68R	Trim into momentum spikes, then trail under the 20 EMA until momentum truly breaks. Max swing in window: ~8.92R.

Beginner	Intermediate	Expert
Hold only while price remains above the rising AVWAP. If the close slips under that line, cut the position and reassess.	Add on tight consolidations above prior highs instead of chasing wide bars. Let the trend earn the add.	Use high-call-activity squeeze days to press only if spot accepts above the dealer pressure zone instead of stalling into it.

REAL-MARKET CASE STUDY 3 | IBIT EXPANSION LEG

Crypto ETF expression of a broadening participation phase.

THESIS A base resolves higher and the ETF wrapper begins to accept above its anchored value, confirming the underlying risk-on regime.	TRIGGER Daily close through the top of the base with expanding participation and price holding above AVWAP.	FAILURE Break back into the base and close under the breakout shelf; that converts the move into a failed expansion.
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Window volume profile is approximated on the right edge for non-FX charts; FX uses ATR in the lower pane.

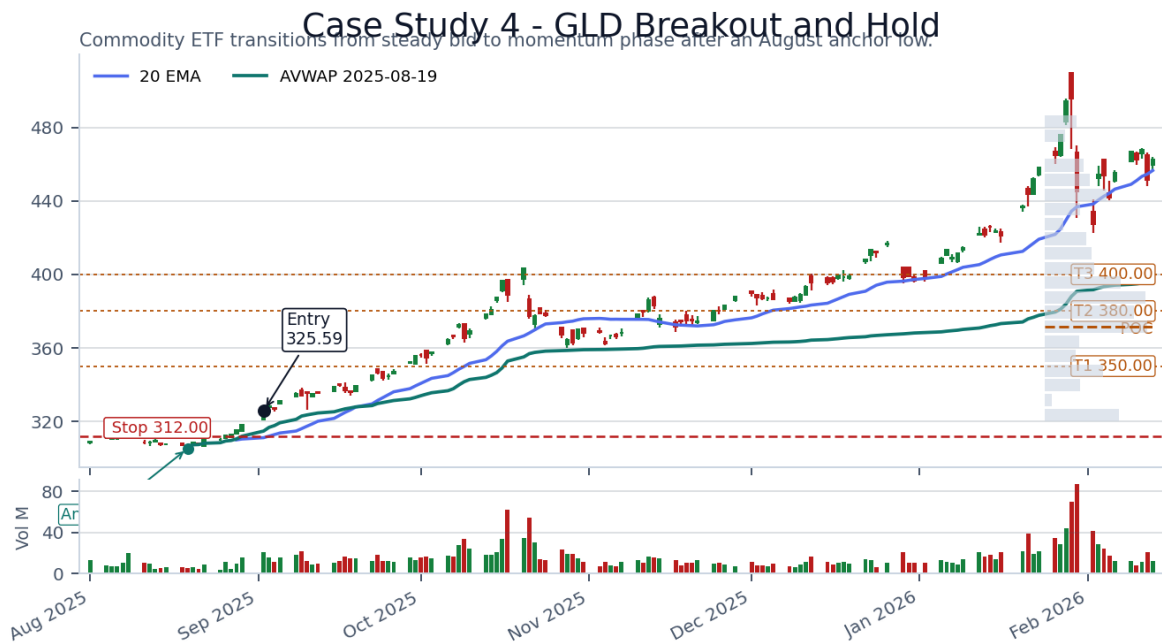
Entry	Stop	Targets	R map	Management
49.57	46.50	53.00 / 56.00 / 60.00	1.12R / 2.09R / 3.40R	Take first trim quickly if the breakout extends too far from value, then only re-add if the next pullback is shallow. Max swing in window: ~3.97R.

Beginner	Intermediate	Expert
Use the closing breakout only. If the next day cannot stay above the breakout shelf, step aside instead of negotiating.	Add only after one to two sessions of acceptance above the breakout, not on the very first emotional gap.	Press size when overnight BTC strength is confirmed by the ETF open rather than faded by it; wrapper and underlying must agree.

REAL-MARKET CASE STUDY 4 | GLD BREAKOUT AND HOLD

Commodity ETF trend phase after a clean August anchor low.

THESIS A steady bid transitions into a momentum phase as the ETF holds above AVWAP and the 20 EMA turns into a reliable trend guide.	TRIGGER Breakout above the compression shelf with rising AVWAP underneath and the close holding near the upper end of the range.	FAILURE Weekly rejection back through the shelf or a decisive loss of AVWAP marks exhaustion rather than continuation.
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Window volume profile is approximated on the right edge for non-FX charts; FX uses ATR in the lower pane.

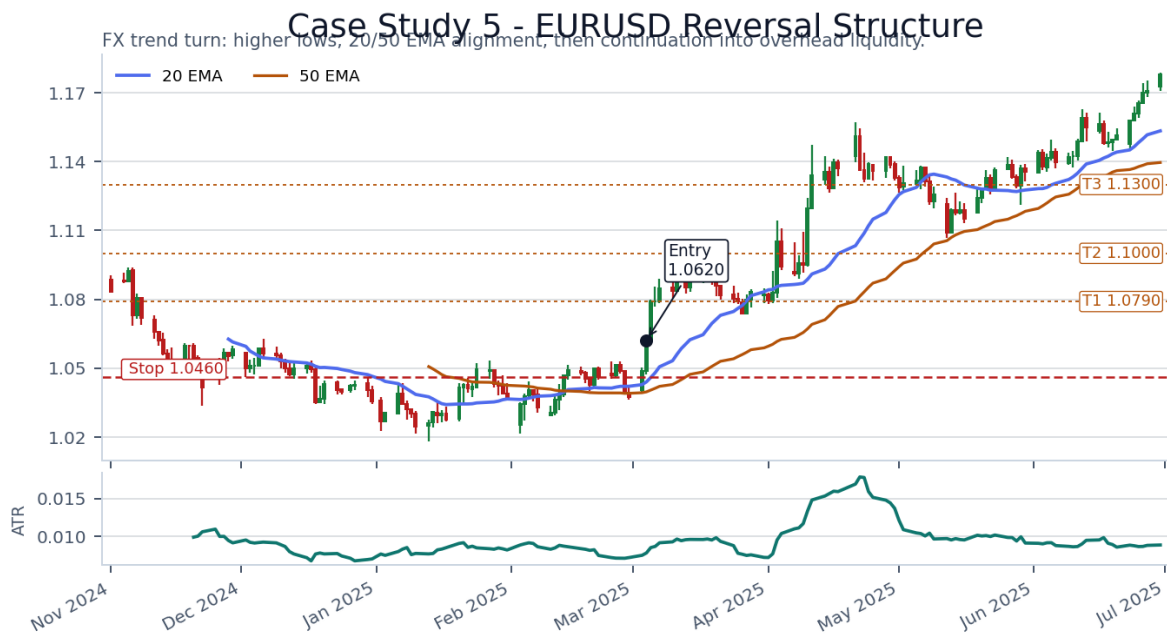
Entry	Stop	Targets	R map	Management
325.59	312.00	350.00 / 380.00 / 400.00	1.80R / 4.00R / 5.48R	Do not chase vertical extension. Add on orderly pullbacks that contract in range and volume, then trail a partial position. Max swing in window: ~13.55R.

Beginner	Intermediate	Expert
Trade on a closing basis only. Commodity momentum often looks strongest right before a poor chase entry.	Pyramid only when the pullback respects the 20 EMA and the next bar closes back in the trend direction.	Cross-check gold with the dollar and real-rate backdrop; press size when the macro tape reinforces the chart instead of fighting it.

REAL-MARKET CASE STUDY 5 | EURUSD REVERSAL STRUCTURE

FX trend turn built from higher lows and moving-average realignment.

THESIS The pair stops making lower lows, builds a higher-low structure, then realigns the 20 and 50 EMAs before continuation.	TRIGGER Daily close above the 50 EMA after the base and then a first pullback that refuses to break the higher low.	FAILURE Lose the higher low and reclaim zone. Once the base fails, the reversal thesis is invalid.
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Window volume profile is approximated on the right edge for non-FX charts; FX uses ATR in the lower pane.

Entry	Stop	Targets	R map	Management
1.0620	1.0460	1.0790 / 1.1000 / 1.1300	1.06R / 2.37R / 4.24R	Treat the overlap session as the place to add or defend; outside active hours, reduce and wait for confirmation. Max swing in window: ~7.29R.

Beginner	Intermediate	Expert
Take the closing signal and keep the stop below the higher low. Ignore intraday noise unless the daily structure breaks.	Add only when the first retrace holds the 20 EMA and London/New York overlap supports continuation.	Press only when dollar index and front-end rate expectations move in the same direction as the FX thesis.

Pre-trade checklist and review sheet

Use this page before size goes on. The goal is not to predict; the goal is to verify that the trade deserves risk.

Checklist item	Yes	Notes
Catalyst or regime shift is identified	☐	
Location is defined (AVWAP, value, prior high/low, shelf)	☐	
Flow is confirming (options, DOM, breadth, cross-check)	☐	
The trade is inside a thick liquidity window	☐	
Invalidation is written before entry	☐	
Scale plan and profit-taking plan are written	☐	
Total correlation heat is within limits	☐	

Entry plan	Stop / invalidation	Target map	If wrong, I exit because...

Post-trade review: Did the setup have location? Did flow agree? Did I trade inside the right session? Did I follow the stop without negotiation?

Student drills and instructor prompts

Student drill	Instructor prompt
Mark the anchor and write a one-sentence bias before looking at indicators.	What inventory is trapped here and what price would prove that thesis wrong?
Circle the thick session window and explain why this trade should pay there.	If this works only in thin liquidity, what size should it really get?
Write the exact invalidation in price terms, not emotional terms.	What would make you add? What would make you reduce even if P&L is green?
Grade the setup 1-5 on regime, location, flow, execution, and risk.	Which of the five layers is weakest and how should that change sizing?
Replay the case and journal whether you improved entry, management, or patience.	Did the trader follow the plan or merely survive the outcome?

Promotion ladder

Beginner	Intermediate	Expert
Can mark location and respect a stop.	Can split entries and manage size.	Can press only when all layers align.
Uses closing signals and simple invalidation.	Understands session behavior and pullback quality.	Understands inventory, flow pressure, and when not to press.
Primary goal: survive.	Primary goal: build repeatable process.	Primary goal: scale size without losing discipline.

Pine Script integrations and methodology notes

Below is a lightweight Pine v5 pattern for stacking session VWAP with a manual anchored VWAP. For equities, anchor at a major gap low/high or earnings day. For FX and commodities, anchor at the event candle or the structural low that reset inventory.

```
//@version=5
indicator("Desk VWAP Stack", overlay=true)
anchorTime = input.time(timestamp("2025-04-07T00:00:00"), "AVWAP anchor")
showSess   = input.bool(true, "Show session VWAP")

tp = hlc3
var float num = na
var float den = na
newAnchor = time >= anchorTime and time[1] < anchorTime

if newAnchor
    num := tp * volume
    den := volume
else if time >= anchorTime
    num += tp * volume
    den += volume

avwap = den != 0 ? num / den : na
plot(showSess ? ta.vwap(tp) : na, "Session VWAP", color=color.blue, linewidth=2)
plot(time >= anchorTime ? avwap : na, "AVWAP", color=color.teal, linewidth=2)
```

Methodology note

Case studies use public daily OHLCV snapshots and rules-based entries on the signal-day close. Targets are training objectives, not forecasts. The options flow and DOM pages are schematic training visuals meant to teach how a desk thinks about pressure, acceptance, and confirmation.

Data note: charts in this edition were reconstructed from public daily market data. Before using any setup live, replace daily reconstructions with your own intraday execution data, fill assumptions, and compliance language.